

Are Business Intelligence Tools Really Intelligent?



Users of Business Intelligence (BI) tools have several issues to contend with. The primary concern relates to whether these tools are really intelligent and future ready. This article highlights some issues and presents a wish list for BI tools of the future.

As businesses expand and the users increase, as the volume of data grows, as databases change and more new software and other technologies get incorporated, it is observed that a Business Intelligence (BI) solution is unable to adapt to these changes. Of course, most BI software is more or less generic in nature with features such as report, dashboard, ad hoc, cache, security, etc. What it lacks is future-ready architecture. This either results in business needs being compromised or dropped, an expensive switch to the use of best-of-breed solutions, or a firm choosing to develop its own solution in-house or by outsourcing it. This results in a waste of money and time—searching for a new BI tool, hiring technical resources and implementing the solution.

So, why should business users adjust their requirements when, ideally, it should be the other way around?

As businesses grow, their expectations from a BI tool keep increasing and since these tools are generally not able to live up to the growing expectations, they get abandoned. This throws up an important question, 'Are BI tools really intelligent?'

An ideal case would be to have a BI tool which is future-ready and developer-friendly, and hence is flexible and extensible. With the growing and ever-changing business requirements, IT staff would then be able to accommodate the advanced requirements by adding features, adopting new technology and hence justifying the investments made. Ideally, such a BI framework should not be bound by any tool or technology limitations and be able to adapt to any sort of requirement—current or future. This would be a developers' paradise, giving them the liberty to do or create anything, and the business users' dream, since whatever they seek can be achieved without compromises. This will also reduce a firm's dependence on the BI vendor for any additional functionality

or patches/releases based on their product roadmap, since an in-house team would be able to add functionality.

Mentioned below are some of the instances wherein current BI tools do not match with their requirements, and need to provide much better flexibility. You may identify with some of these situations.

1. Can I add new data type as source?

Most BI tools support commonly used data sources, which are limited in number. If any new database type is to be added as a data source, it may not be possible without the database vendor providing the connect. Also, in case the data storage technology is different, like it is with Hadoop, one has to rely on the BI vendor to come up with a new patch or version. Such requests generally take a lot of time to be addressed by BI vendors who have shifted their focus from product innovation to sales. Wouldn't it be great if the developers themselves were able to add data sources, APIs, etc, and enhance the tool?

2. There's a new API in the market. Can I fetch data from it?

BI tools generally come with native connectors to certain popular APIs. But with the changing times and requirements, new and more relevant APIs come up. Fetching data from APIs other than the pre-installed ones may be impossible or often very difficult. In such a scenario, one may feel the BI tools available today are not very future-ready.

3. Charting options are few, limiting the usage of advanced analytics

After connecting to a database, reports or a dashboard are created. Most of the BI tools come with out-of-the-box charting options, which are limited in scope and may not suffice. Though some BI